IDEATION PHASE

Streamlining IT Procurement

Brainstorm and idea prioritization for standard laptop orders with Flow Designer

Session detail	Working value
Date	1 October 2026
Team / facilitator	SWTID-2026-2670
Project	Standard laptop order automation
Focus	Routine, policy-compliant laptop requests

Purpose and intended outcome

Explore how a guided request and automated workflow can make routine laptop orders easier for employees and more predictable for IT, procurement, finance, and fulfillment. The session output is a shortlist for discovery; policy thresholds, integrations, and approval rules still need validation with process owners.

Step 1 Define the problem

Problem statement	How might we
Employees and managers may need to navigate inconsistent forms, unclear approvals, and status chasing to order a standard laptop. IT and procurement teams may recheck routine details manually before fulfillment. The actual baseline and pain points should be confirmed with request and ticket data.	How might we make an eligible standard laptop request complete, policy-checked, routed, and visible through delivery with minimal avoidable handoffs, while keeping exceptions and controls clear?

Session boundaries

In scope for ideation	Route for separate handling
Standard catalog models; employee and manager details; cost center and delivery location; eligibility checks; approvals required by policy; order and fulfillment status; asset and handoff updates.	Non-standard specifications; accessibility accommodations; urgent replacements; executive exceptions; international or restricted locations; budget or policy exceptions; unavailable stock.

What better looks like

- A requester submits complete information once and can see the next step and current status.
- Routine requests are checked consistently, with only policy-defined approvals and exceptions sent to people.
- Procurement and IT can see demand, blockers, order status, and the handoff into asset assignment.

Step 2 Generate and group ideas

Generate broadly first. Treat these as concepts to test, not confirmed requirements. Flow Designer is the orchestration layer in the concept; the catalog, policies, data sources, and connected systems must be confirmed during discovery.

Idea bank

Idea	Theme	Concept
Guided catalog request	Request experience	Offer a small set of approved laptop bundles and ask only for required delivery and business details.
Eligibility pre-check	Policy and data	Check worker status, role or device eligibility, location, cost center, and existing assignment before routing.
Smart completeness checks	Request experience	Flag missing or conflicting fields at submission and explain what the requester needs to correct.
Policy-based approval path	Approvals	Route only the approvals required by the applicable policy; auto-continue where no approval is required.
Exception queue	Exceptions	Send non-standard model, policy, budget, location, or urgency cases to a named owner with reason and context.
Inventory-aware fulfillment	Fulfillment	Check available stock or lead time before committing; offer an approved alternative or set expectations.
Order handoff	Integrations	Create or route a purchase request to the procurement system with the approved configuration and cost details.
Status notifications	Visibility	Notify the requester and manager at meaningful milestones and surface a single status view.
Asset and setup handoff	IT operations	Capture serial or asset details on receipt and trigger assignment, imaging, security, and employee handoff tasks.
Operational dashboard	Measurement	Track request volume, elapsed time by stage, rework, approval waits, exception reasons, and fulfillment outcomes.

Idea clusters

Cluster	Ideas that belong together	Design question
Make requests easy	Guided catalog; completeness checks	Can the requester choose the right standard option without knowing procurement terminology?
Apply controls consistently	Eligibility pre-check; policy approvals; exception queue	Which rules are authoritative, and who owns exceptions?
Connect the handoffs	Inventory check; order handoff; asset/setup handoff	Which systems exchange data, and what is the reliable status source?
Make progress visible	Milestone notifications; operational dashboard	Which events matter to employees and service owners?

Concept flow for a standard request

Use this as a starting sequence for a Flow Designer workshop. Confirm available triggers, actions, integrations, and approval policies in the target instance before turning it into a design.

Stage	Conceptual workflow action	Route / outcome
1. Submit	Employee selects an approved laptop bundle and enters required details.	Incomplete or conflicting data returns for correction with a clear explanation.
2. Validate	Check requester eligibility, assigned device, cost center, location, and catalog choice against agreed data and rules.	Ineligible or uncertain cases go to an exception owner; do not silently bypass a control.
3. Approve	Evaluate the request against the approved policy and route required approvals with context and timeout/escalation rules.	No additional approval only when policy explicitly permits it; rejected requests close with a reason.
4. Source	Check stock or lead time, then create or route the approved purchase request.	Unavailable items trigger an approved alternative or a buyer review.
5. Fulfill	Track purchase, receipt, asset capture, configuration, and employee handoff tasks.	Keep procurement and IT ownership visible at each handoff.
6. Close and learn	Confirm receipt, assignment, and requester notification; retain an auditable outcome.	Measure cycle time, rework, exceptions, and fulfillment against an agreed baseline.

Guardrails to design in

- Use approved catalog choices and an explicit eligibility rule; keep exception paths visible and owned.
- Pass only necessary employee and purchasing data between systems, with access and audit controls aligned to policy.
- Handle duplicate submissions, missing integrations, timeouts, rejected approvals, and out-of-stock items deliberately.
- Avoid promising automatic purchasing until procurement controls, budget checks, and system-of-record ownership are agreed.

Step 3 Prioritize ideas

Score each concept from 1 (low) to 5 (high). Impact means expected reduction in effort, delay, or confusion. Feasibility means likely ability to deliver with available process, data, and integrations. Effort uses 1 for low effort and 5 for high effort. Weighted score = 2 × impact + feasibility − effort. Scores are workshop hypotheses and should be revisited after discovery.

Concept	Impact	Feas.	Effort	Score	Initial disposition
Guided catalog and complete request	5	5	2	13	Start here
Policy-based routing and approvals	5	4	3	11	Start here
Status milestones and notifications	4	4	2	10	Start here
Exception queue with ownership	4	4	3	9	Pilot alongside core
Eligibility pre-check	5	3	4	9	Validate data first
Procurement handoff integration	5	3	5	8	Discovery dependency
Inventory-aware fulfillment	4	3	4	7	Phase after stock source confirmed
Asset and setup handoff	4	3	4	7	Coordinate with IT operations
Operational dashboard	3	4	3	7	Define measures and baseline

Recommended first slice

Pilot a guided standard-laptop request, submission-time completeness checks, policy-based approval routing, a named exception queue, and milestone status updates. Initially stop at a controlled procurement handoff if purchasing integration or inventory data is not ready. Add asset and setup closure once ownership and system-of-record fields are agreed.

Discovery questions before build

- What makes a request “standard”: model bundles, eligibility, geography, budget, and replacement rules? Who owns each rule?

- Which approvals are mandatory, conditional, or unnecessary, and what are the escalation and delegation rules?

- Which systems own worker, cost center, catalog, inventory, purchase order, asset, and fulfillment status data?

- What baseline will we compare against: end-to-end time, touch time, rework, incomplete requests, exception rate, or requester satisfaction?

- Who monitors failed flows and integrations, and how are retries, duplicates, and manual recovery handled?

Workshop decision and owners

Decision / follow-up	**Owner**	**Due**
Confirm standard request definition and policy rules	To assign	To set
Map current request-to-delivery steps and baseline	To assign	To set
Validate data sources and integration boundaries	To assign	To set
Select pilot scope, success measures, and exception owners	To assign	To set